

Spotting Manufactured Popularity Online

A one-period case study in evaluating engagement as evidence — not proof.

GRADE LEVEL	TIME	SUBJECTS	FORMAT
9–12 (adaptable 6–8)	45–50 min, one period	ELA, Digital Citizenship, CTE	Discussion + data activity

🎯 Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Define *manufactured engagement* and explain how it differs from organic popularity
- Interpret a real, published dataset to identify signs of coordinated engagement inflation
- Apply a repeatable four-part evaluation framework to content they haven't seen before
- Explain why practicing this skill on an unfamiliar platform still builds a transferable habit

📖 Background for the Teacher

This lesson uses findings from the **SPOTAPOD Analysis Repository**, an independent, aggregate-only, non-peer-reviewed analysis of three datasets tied to LinkedIn "engagement pod" services — tools that sell coordinated batches of likes and comments to make a post look more popular than it organically is. **LinkedIn requires users to be 16+ and is not a platform most students use daily** — that's deliberate. Using an unfamiliar platform lets students practice the underlying evaluation skill without the exercise turning into a referendum on an app they're personally attached to. The skill transfers; the specific platform is just the example.

What this research is not: a claim about any teen-focused platform, and not evidence for or against any pending legislation. It's a real, documented illustration of one mechanism — inflated engagement lending false credibility to a claim — used here purely for its teaching value.

🕒 Warm-Up (5 minutes)

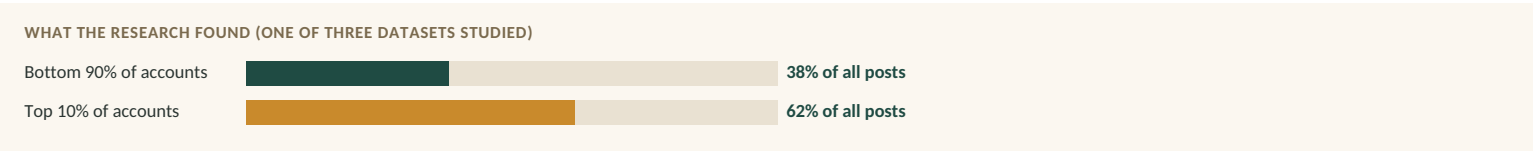
Ask students, as a quick show of hands or think-pair-share:

DISCUSSION PROMPT

"Have you ever seen a post with a huge number of likes, where the comments seemed generic or off? What did you think was actually going on?"

🔗 Main Activity (25 minutes): Reading the Data

Step 1 — Show the concentration finding. Present the chart below and ask students what it implies about where "popularity" on this platform actually comes from.



Step 2 — Introduce a real recurring pattern. Researchers found the exact same "success story" template — a claim that months of job-search silence ended the moment the poster ran their résumé through an AI tool — posted, word for word, **533 separate times** by different accounts.

ASK THE CLASS

"If 533 different people all had the exact same story happen to them, in the exact same words — what does that tell you about whether the story is real?"

Step 3 — Apply the Four Signals framework. In pairs, have students evaluate a sample post (real or teacher-provided) against these four questions:

1. Numbers vs. comments Do the comments match the like count, or are they generic and thin?	2. Speed vs. history Did this suddenly take off, or build up the way real popularity usually does?
3. Urgency vs. patience Is it rushing you to act, using its popularity as the reason?	4. Specific vs. generic Could this "success story" apply to literally anyone?

 Discussion Questions (10 minutes)

Bring the class back together and discuss:

1. Who benefits when a post looks more popular than it actually is?
2. Does finding out a post is templated change how you feel about the advice inside it? Why or why not?
3. Where might this same pattern show up on platforms you personally use?
4. What's the real difference between "popular because people found it valuable" and "popular because it was engineered to look that way"? Can you always tell which one you're looking at?

 Extension / Take-Home (Optional)

Ask students to find one example, on a platform they actually use, of content that repeats a template they've now learned to recognize — a phrase, format, or "success story" that shows up more than once. The goal is spotting the *pattern*, not calling out any individual account: students should describe the pattern in their own words rather than screenshotting or naming a specific person. Discuss findings as a warm-up next class.

 Standards Alignment

This lesson maps to the *analyze* and *evaluate* competencies common to state media literacy frameworks and to NAMLE's Core Principles of Media Literacy Education:

Competency	How this lesson addresses it
Access	Students engage with a real, cited, publicly available dataset rather than a hypothetical example.
Analyze	Students interpret a concentration statistic and a recurring-template finding to draw their own conclusions.
Evaluate	The Four Signals framework gives students a repeatable, transferable method for judging credibility independent of engagement counts.
Act	The extension activity asks students to apply the skill to their own platform use going forward.

Source: SPOTAPOD Analysis Repository — an independent, aggregate-only, non-peer-reviewed analysis of three engagement-pod datasets (github.com/DreamITSSoftware/SPOTAPOD). The underlying research is about LinkedIn, a professional platform for users 16+, and career-advice content specifically. It is used here solely as documented, illustrative teaching material for a general media-literacy skill — not as a claim about any teen-focused platform, and not as a statement of, or evidence for, any pending legislation.

Companion resource for families: "How to Help Your Teen Spot Manufactured Popularity Online" (parent guide, same source).